UNIQUE MARKETING ISSUES · ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Found, chosen, *booked.*

How an entrepreneurial firm finds its customers, and how AI finds it.

LECTURER

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MODULE

MKT101 / ENT101

Unique Marketing Issues

DATE

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A3, Central Administration



THE ENTREPRENEURIAL DILEMMA

The Ruka Maldives *dilemma*

PROPERTY	Ruka Maldives
LOCATION	Dhiffushi, North Malé Atoll
SIZE	12 rooms · opened 2025
WEBSITE	*None of its own*

> *How do classic marketing frameworks still apply when an AI engine is the gatekeeper between an entrepreneur and its customers?*

THE AI SEARCH PROBLEM



Hundreds of rooms. The AI shows *three.*

Will Ruka make the list?



abdullamuizfuad.github.io/GEO-Visibility-/demo

YOUR TURN

Be the *traveller.*

01 Scan the code with your camera

02 Choose the traveller you are

03 Watch the AI choose your stay

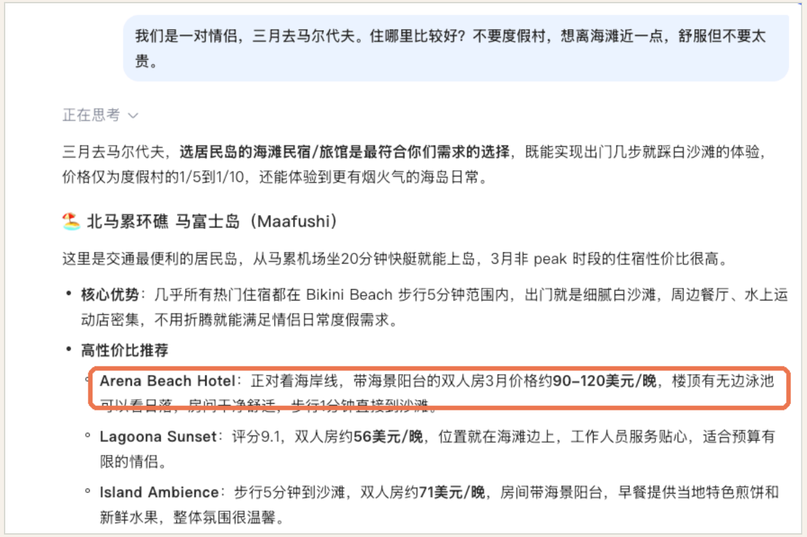
04 Look for Ruka...

> *Pause at the question: “Why do you think the AI left Ruka out?”*

Same questions, *real* AI engines

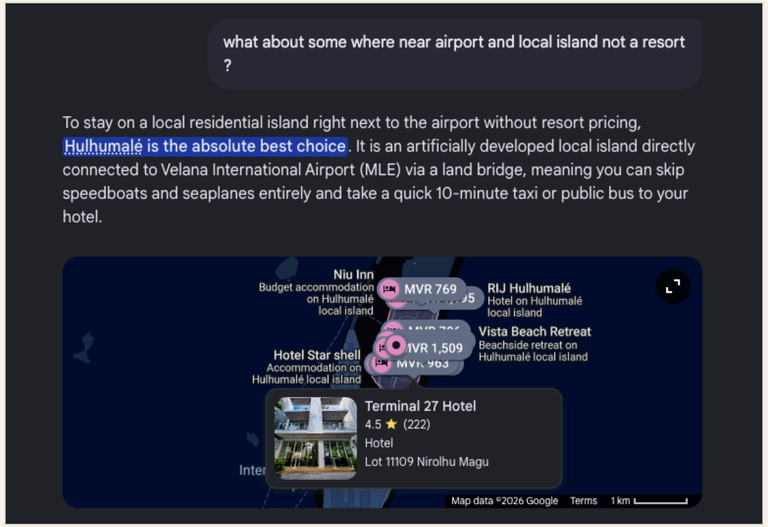
Baidu

In Chinese: “We’re a couple… not a resort, near the beach.”



Google AI Mode

“Near the airport, a local island, not a resort.”



0

times Ruka Maldives was named

Arena Beach Hotel: Baidu’s first pick for couples, Gemini’s for families

Dhiffushi recommended, with **Athiri Residence**, not Ruka

Google’s picks all carry a **rating, map pin & website**

Four questions every *venture* must answer

By the end of this session, you can answer each for Ruka.

01

Who?

Segment the market, choose a target and establish a unique position.

02

Why us?

Define a brand and explain how it builds trust and brand equity for a new firm.

03

What & how?

Apply the 4Ps: product, price, place and promotion.

04

Closing the deal

Walk through the seven-step sales process.

Grounded in Barringer & Ireland, *Entrepreneurship*, “Unique Marketing Issues”

OBJECTIVE ONE

Segment, target, *position.*

Three steps entrepreneurial firms use to find the customers they can serve best.

01

Segment

WHO COULD STAY?

Divers · Families · Beach & kite lovers · Honeymooners · Budget couples

Divide a broad market into groups that share needs and characteristics.

02

Target

WHO DO WE SERVE BEST?

Beach & kite-loving couples, mid-budget, near Malé

Choose the niche where the firm has a real advantage.

03

Position

WHY US, NOT THEM?

“The quiet twelve-room beach guesthouse on Dhiffushi: steps from the sand, ten minutes from Kite Beach.”

AI LENS

An AI engine matches a traveller’s intent to your position. A vague one (“affordable luxury”) fails; it must be **specific, provable and consistent everywhere.**

OBJECTIVE TWO

A brand is a promise people, *and AI,* recognise

> A brand is the set of attributes, positive or negative, that people associate with a company.
>
> *Barringer & Ireland, Entrepreneurship*

Liability of newness: trust without a track record

Brand equity: perceived value and loyalty

Price premium and repeat stays

Recognition by people and machines

A FRACTURED FOOTPRINT		TEACHING SCENARIO
BOOKING SITE	Ruka Inn *Reviews split across names*	+960 7XX **1234**
MAP LISTING	Ruka Guest House *Treated as a separate business*	**no phone**
SOCIAL MEDIA	Ruka Maldives *Customers confused; booking signals lost*	+960 9XX **5678**

A UNIFIED FOOTPRINT

Ruka Maldives

Same name, address and phone everywhere, so every review and booking signal builds one brand's equity, and one entity an AI can recognise.

The marketing mix in the *generative* era

01

Product

Core benefits, not just features.

GEO twist: AI needs verifiable facts, not adjectives.

> **12 A/C rooms · private baths · steps from the beach · breakfast included**

02

Price

Cost-based or **value-based** (what guests perceive it is worth).

GEO twist: publish clear ranges and cancellation terms so AI agents can qualify guests instantly.

03

Place

Direct sales versus **intermediaries** (OTAs, travel agents).

GEO twist: AI answer engines are the newest intermediary in the distribution chain.

04

Promotion

Advertising, public relations, social media and guerrilla marketing.

GEO twist: generative engine optimisation, alongside reviews and social media.

OBJECTIVE FOUR

AI opens doors; *you* close the sale

1 **Prospect for leads**
Travellers looking for a Dhiffushi stay
AI-ASSISTED

2 **Initial contact**
The first answer to an enquiry
AI-ASSISTED

3 **Qualify the lead**
Budget, dates and fit confirmed
AI-ASSISTED

4 **Sales presentation**
Rooms and amenities presented
AI-ASSISTED

5 **Meet objections**
“Is it quiet enough to work?”
HUMAN TOUCH

6 **Close the sale**
Deposit and confirmation
HUMAN TOUCH

7 **Follow-up & retention**
Reviews and repeat stays
HUMAN TOUCH

Steps one to four: the AI finds, filters and presents for you. A guest who clicks through arrives pre-qualified.

Steps five to seven: objections, the close and the relationship still belong to the guesthouse.

DISCUSSION

If AI handles steps one to four, how does the role of a Maldivian guesthouse manager change?

Turn to your neighbour. Which touchpoints should stay human, and which can be automated?

01

Less time answering repetitive first enquiries about price and location.

02

More weight on relationship selling: objections, on-site hospitality, steps five to seven.

03

Keeping digital facts accurate becomes part of the manager's job.

Tap “Continue”

YOUR TURN

Now, make Ruka *visible.*

BRAND	One name, address and phone
PRODUCT	Facts, not adjectives
PRICE	A clear range and cancellation terms
PLACE	A bookable channel of its own

AI VISIBILITY — Strong

TRAVELLER: A BEACH-LOVING COUPLE

1 *Ruka Maldives*

2 Stone Hotels Dhiffushi

3 Arena Beach Hotel

Picked the dive couple? Ruka still loses to Reveries. That is positioning.

Measuring learning: from memory to *application*

FORMATIVE — *Understand*

Exit ticket

"In one sentence, state Ruka's market position, and explain how an AI engine could verify it."

Two minutes, end of class · instant feedback

REMEMBERING

SUMMATIVE — *Apply*

Exam question

"Using a Maldivian guesthouse, explain the seven-step sales process and identify which steps are most affected by AI answer engines."

Short answer · 10 marks

GROUP PROJECT · 30% — *Analyse · Create*

AI visibility audit

Audit a real local guesthouse across ChatGPT, Gemini, Google and Booking.com, then propose an improved STP, brand strategy and 4Ps mix.

Rubric: diagnosis 30 · recommendations 50 · pitch 20

APPLYING IN THE FIELD →

Found. Chosen. *Booked.*

01 **STP:** own a specific, provable position

02 **Brand:** stay consistent across every channel

03 **4Ps:** clear, verifiable facts for people and AI

04 **Seven steps:** AI handles discovery; people build trust and close

MY TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

Students learn marketing best by applying core theory to real, local challenges. I teach through live case studies, authentic problem-solving and practical digital strategies that prepare graduates for a changing business landscape.

Abdulla Muiz Fuad

Questions?

References & *sources*

Barringer, B. R., & Ireland, R. D. *Entrepreneurship: Successfully launching new ventures*. Pearson. Chapter 11: Unique marketing issues (chapter number varies by edition).

Morand, J.-C., & Schegg, R. (2026). *Be visible to AI: The keys to semantic optimization and GEO for hotels* [White paper]. HES-SO Valais-Wallis. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19109201

Aggarwal, P., et al. (2024). GEO: Generative engine optimization. *Proceedings of the 30th ACM SIGKDD Conference on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining*.

Ruka Maldives is used with the owner's permission. Ruka, Stone Hotels Dhiffushi, Reveries Diving Village and Arena Beach Hotel are described only with publicly listed facts; the "fractured footprint" is a teaching scenario. The phone demo is a scripted simulation, not a live AI. AI answers were captured on 4 November 2026.